

Dropback Concepts: Smash, Flood, Mesh, Levels, Dagger, and Four Verticals

The two- and three-receiver combinations behind almost every pass thrown more than ten yards, and how a quarterback reads each one

Third-and-8, late in the first half. The offense lines up with two receivers on each side. Before the snap the camera shows both safeties standing thirteen yards deep and both cornerbacks only five yards off the ball, flat-footed, watching the quarterback. The ball is snapped, the quarterback takes three quick steps back from the shotgun, and the outside receiver on the right runs five yards and turns around. The cornerback in front of him does exactly what he has been coached to do: he squats on that receiver. The ball sails over his head to the inside receiver, who has run ten yards up the field and angled toward the sideline, into the space behind the cornerback and in front of the safety. First down. On the replay the analyst circles the two routes with his telestrator and says one word: *smash*. Why was the cornerback wrong when he did what he was told? How did the quarterback know, before the snap, where the ball was going? And why does the same two-route pattern, under one name or another, show up in every playbook in the league? This chapter is about those patterns: the **dropback concepts** that make up most of an offense's passing game beyond the quick throws.

You'll be able to...

- Say what a pass concept is, and why offenses teach concepts rather than individual routes.
- Draw fourteen dropback concepts (smash, flood, curl-flat, levels, drive, shallow cross, dagger, Y-cross, mesh, angle, four verticals, post-wheel, scissors and yankee) and point to the defender each one puts in a bind.
- Sort any concept into one of four families (vertical stretch, horizontal stretch, triangle, or man-beater) and name the coverage it is built to beat.
- Walk the quarterback's progression on each concept, from his first look to the checkdown.
- Spot a rub route on a replay and say where it crosses the line into an illegal pick.
- Explain tags and route conversions: how one call becomes the right answer against several coverages.

You'll need

- **Concepts, leverage and the pre-snap read** from *The Quick Game*: a concept puts two receivers on opposite sides of one defender; a defender's leverage (inside or outside the receiver) tells the quarterback where to throw; stick and snag are the short versions of ideas this chapter takes deeper.
- **Routes, drops and reads** from *Passing Fundamentals*: the route tree (hitch, curl, dig, corner, post, go, seam, wheel); the progression, the order in which the quarterback looks at his receivers; the high-low and horizontal stretches of a conflict defender; and the option route.
- **Man, zone and the shell** from *A First Look at Defense*: in man coverage each defender follows a receiver, in zone each guards an area; one-high means one deep safety in the middle, two-high means two.
- **Protection** from *Pass Protection*: deeper throws need the line (and sometimes a back and a tight end) to hold up for three seconds or more.

What a pass concept is

A **pass concept** is a set of routes designed to work together on one play, usually by putting one or two defenders in a position where whatever they do leaves a receiver open. You met the idea in *The Quick Game*, where slant-flat and stick each pinned one defender between two receivers. This chapter takes the same idea deeper down the field, where the routes take longer to develop and the defenders in conflict are cornerbacks, linebackers and safeties instead of a single slot defender.

Why do offenses think in concepts rather than routes? Three reasons, and they explain a lot about how football is coached.

A concept is a sentence; routes are only words. A corner route on its own means nothing. A corner route run over a hitch, against a cornerback who has to choose between them, is a plan. The quarterback doesn't read five receivers one by one; he reads

one or two defenders and lets the concept tell him where the open man will be. That's why concepts are drawn and taught as units, and why a receiver learns not only his route but his partner's.

A name is a shortcut. "Smash" tells two receivers their routes in one syllable, from any formation, on either side of the field. Offenses that name concepts this way can teach a playbook faster and call plays faster, which matters in a two-minute drive or a no-huddle attack. Not every system names its plays like this; some spell out each receiver's route in a long string of words or numbers, and the trade-offs between those styles are the subject of Offensive Systems and Languages, where concept-based terminology gets its full story.

A concept travels. Smash works from a 2x2 formation, from trips, with a tight end as the inside receiver or a running back. Because the conflict is about *space* (the gap between a cornerback sitting short and a safety playing deep), the same concept can be dressed up in a dozen formations, which makes it hard for a defense to recognize from the alignment alone.

Common misconception

"Every pass play has one intended receiver." Almost none do. A concept has a *first look*, the route it was designed around, but it's built so that whichever choice the key defender makes, somebody else is open. When an announcer says the quarterback "went to his second read," that isn't a failure of the play. It is often the play working as drawn.

What changes when the quarterback drops back

The quick game lives on throws that leave the quarterback's hand in about two seconds, aimed at receivers five or six yards away. Dropback concepts give themselves more time and aim farther, and the numbers show what that buys and what it costs. In the 2025 regular season, throws that traveled less than ten yards past the line of scrimmage left the quarterback's hand after a median of 2.3 seconds; throws of 10 to 19 yards, the home of most of the concepts in this chapter, took 2.8 seconds, and throws of 20 yards or more took 3.1 seconds.¹ That extra half-second is the price of the deeper drop (five steps from under center, or three from the shotgun, in the matched pairs of Passing Fundamentals) and of routes that need ten or fifteen yards to reach the spot where they break.

What does the half-second buy? Value. Those 10-to-19-yard throws averaged about +0.39 expected points added (EPA) per attempt, the course's measure of how much a play changed the offense's scoring chances, against about +0.10 for throws under ten yards. But they were completed only 54% of the time, against 72%, and they were intercepted twice as often (about 3.2% of attempts against 1.6%).

Why it exists, and what it costs

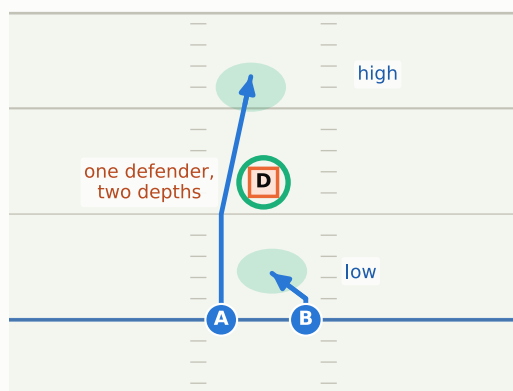
Dropback concepts trade **time and risk for yards**. The offense asks its line to protect for three seconds or more, accepts a lower completion rate and more interceptions, and gets in return the throws that move the ball in big pieces: the 15-yard dig on third-and-8, the corner route that turns a drive into a scoring chance. The quick game keeps an offense on schedule; dropback concepts are how it gets ahead of it. The bill comes in sacks, hits on the quarterback and a pass rush with time to get home, which is why protection (Pass Protection) and dropback concepts are planned together.

Four ways to put a defender in a bind

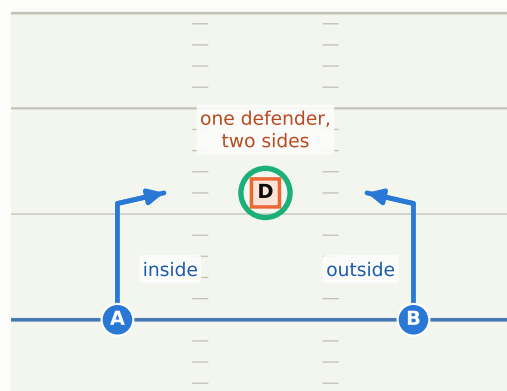
Every concept in this chapter does one of four things to the defense. Learn the four and you can name the purpose of a concept you have never seen, which is most of what "reading" a pass play from the couch means.

¹Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (`air_yards`) joined to nflverse participation data (`time_to_throw`, FTN-sourced), 2025 regular season, pass attempts with sacks and spikes excluded. Median time to throw: 2.2 seconds for throws behind the line of scrimmage, 2.3 seconds for 0–9 air yards, 2.8 seconds for 10–19, and 3.1 seconds for 20 or more. EPA per attempt: +0.10 (0–9 yards), +0.39 (10–19), +0.44 (20+); completion rate 72%, 54% and 37%; interception rate 1.6%, 3.2% and 5.0%.

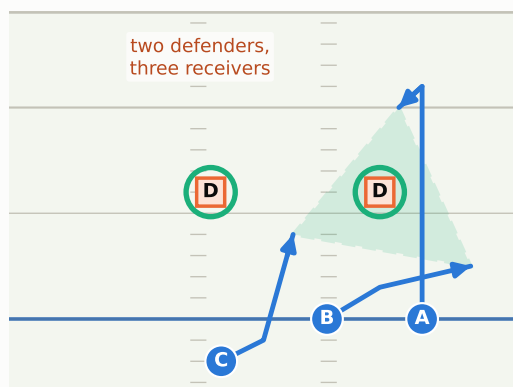
1. Vertical stretch (high-low)



2. Horizontal stretch



3. Triangle



4. Man-beater

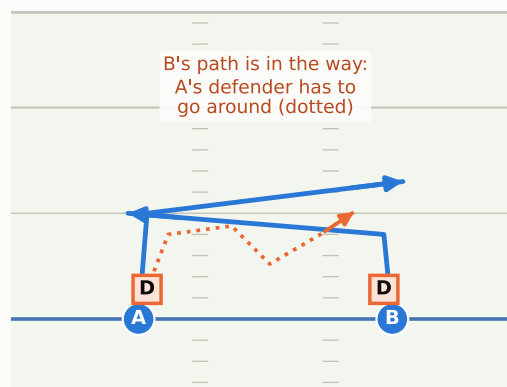


Figure 1: The four families of pass concepts, drawn as small abstract pictures (offense moving up the page). 1. Vertical stretch (high-low): two receivers in one defender's area at two depths; he can stand under the high one or in front of the low one, not both. 2. Horizontal stretch: receivers on both sides of a defender at about the same depth. 3. Triangle: three receivers around two defenders, one high and two low, so the quarterback has a high-low and an inside-outside choice at once. 4. Man-beater: against man coverage there is no area to overload, so the routes cross close to each other and the defenders chasing them have to fight through traffic (the dotted orange line is a defender forced to go around).

1. **Vertical stretch (high-low).** Two receivers in one defender's area, one above him and one below. He can sink under the high route or come up on the low one, not both. This is the high-low read of Passing Fundamentals, and it is the most common family by far: smash, flood, levels, drive, shallow cross, dagger, Y-cross and yankee are all built on it.
2. **Horizontal stretch.** Receivers on both sides of a defender at about the same depth, the horizontal stretch of Passing Fundamentals. Underneath, that's the quick game's spacing; deep, it is four verticals, post-wheel and scissors, which stretch the *deep* defenders side to side.
3. **Triangle.** Three receivers arranged around two defenders. A **triangle read** is a three-receiver read in which the routes form a triangle, one high and two low (or two high and one low), so the quarterback has a high-low *and* an inside-outside choice at once. Snag, from the quick game, is the classic; curl-flat with a third route inside is the dropback version.
4. **Man-beater.** A **man-beater** is a concept designed to beat man coverage. Stretches beat zone defenders, who guard areas; a man defender follows one receiver wherever he goes, so there is no area to overload. Man-beaters win instead with routes that cross close together (so defenders run into traffic), routes that break away from a defender's leverage, and mismatches like a running back against a linebacker. Mesh and the angle route are the classics.

Most real concepts are hybrids (a flood is a vertical stretch that also stretches the flat defender sideways; mesh sits in zone holes when it isn't running away from man defenders), so the family names describe a concept's *main* idea. That idea also tells you what coverage the concept is built to beat, and therefore when an offense will call it. We'll come back to that matchup at the end of the chapter, and What Beats What builds it into a full table.

How to read the plates

The fourteen concepts below are drawn as *plates*, the way a playbook draws them, in one consistent style:

- The offense is in shotgun with 11 personnel (one back, one tight end, three receivers) unless the caption says otherwise: **X** and **Z** are the outside receivers, **H** a slot receiver, **Y** a tight end or second slot, **R** the running back. The ball is in the middle of the field to keep the picture symmetric; in a game, most concepts are aimed at the wide side.
- Blue routes are the concept. **Grey** routes are part of the call but outside the read: they are there to hold defenders in place.
- **Green numbers** are the progression, the order in which the quarterback looks. These are typical teaching orders; every team writes its own, and many change the order by coverage.
- The defense is drawn in the coverage the concept is built to beat. Dashed orange arrows are zone drops; the **ringed** defender is the one in conflict, the man the quarterback reads.
- The label at the top right names the concept's family.

Vertical stretches on the sideline: smash, flood and curl-flat

The first three concepts attack the area near one sideline, where a defense has only two or three defenders and the sideline itself acts as a twelfth defender for the offense: a receiver running toward it has somewhere to go, and the defender has to cover him all the way there.

Smash: the corner over the hitch

Smash pairs two receivers on one side. The outside receiver runs a hitch at five or six yards and turns back to the quarterback. The inside receiver runs a corner route: ten or twelve yards straight up the field, then an angle toward the sideline and the back of the end zone. The defender in conflict is the cornerback on that side.

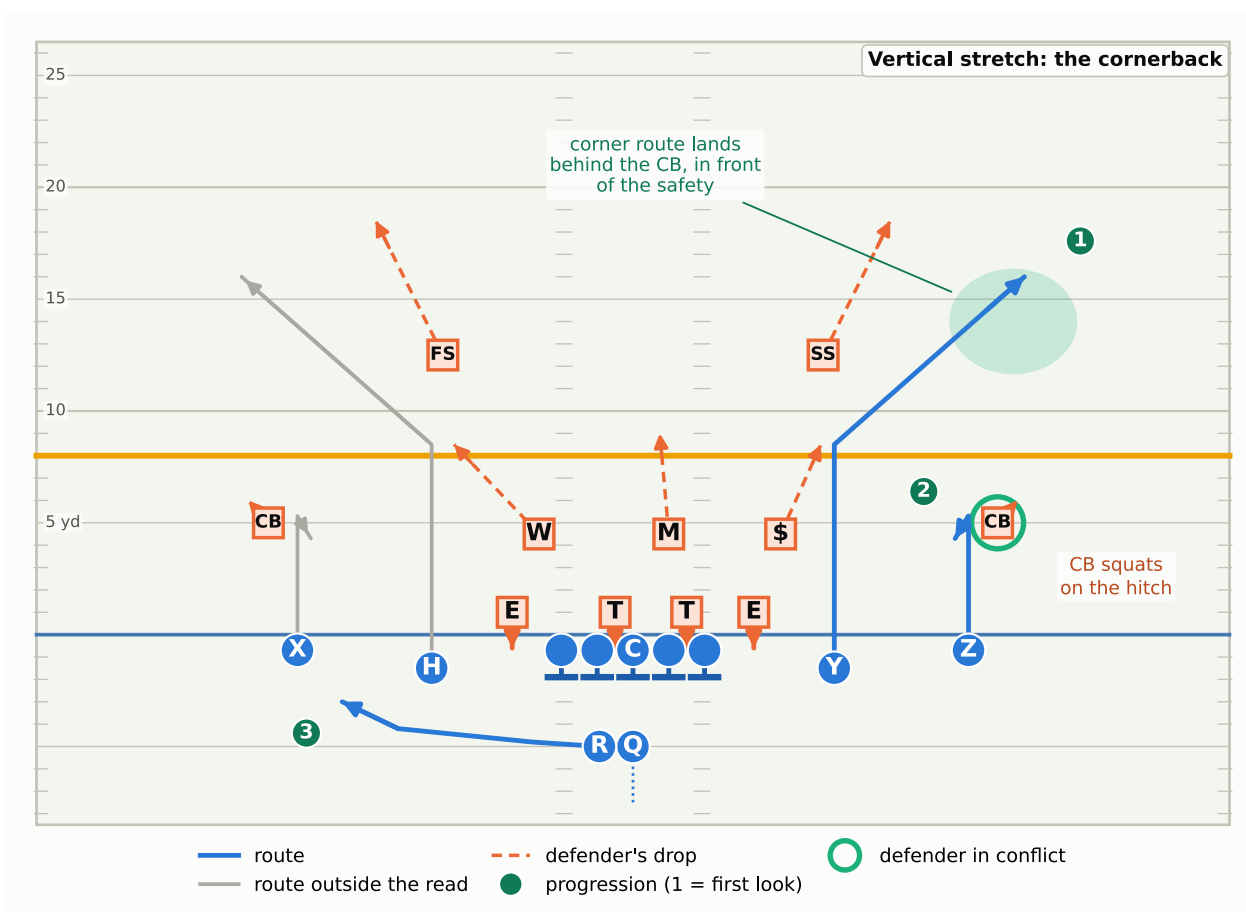


Figure 2: Smash to the offense's right against Cover 2. Z runs a hitch at five yards; Y, from the slot, runs a corner route over him, flattening toward the sideline at about 16 yards. The ringed cornerback squats in the flat, as Cover 2 tells him to, and the strong safety (SS) has the deep half behind him, starting thirteen yards deep and well inside him: the corner route lands in the gap between them (green). The progression reads the cornerback high to low: (1) the corner route if he sits on the hitch, (2) the hitch if he sinks under the corner route, (3) the back as the checkdown. The left side (grey) is often a mirror-image smash, so the quarterback can pick the side he likes before the snap.

Why does it work against Cover 2? Cover 2 splits the deep field between two safeties and asks the cornerbacks to stay short, guarding the flats, so that nothing quick gets thrown to the outside. That leaves a seam of open grass along each sideline between

harder to reach. If the curl-flat defender takes the flat, the sail settles in the space he left, in front of the cornerback, for 12 or 14 yards. If he sinks, the back catches the ball in the flat with open grass in front of him.

Flood's cost is the other side of the field. It sends three receivers to one sideline, so the backside routes are usually just there to hold defenders, and a defense that rotates its coverage toward the flood (a safety rolling down to the flat side at the snap) can outnumber it. That is why flood is so often run off a fake run or with the quarterback rolling toward the flood side; the run fake and the bootleg, which move the defenders before the routes even arrive, are in Play-Action, Bootlegs, and Screens.

Curl-flat: the West Coast triangle

Curl-flat is the high-low you met in Passing Fundamentals: a curl at 10 to 12 yards over a flat route underneath, both in the area of the one defender who guards the short outside zone. As a dropback concept it usually comes with a third route, a back or tight end who settles in a hook route just inside the curl at five or six yards. That third route turns a two-man read into a triangle.

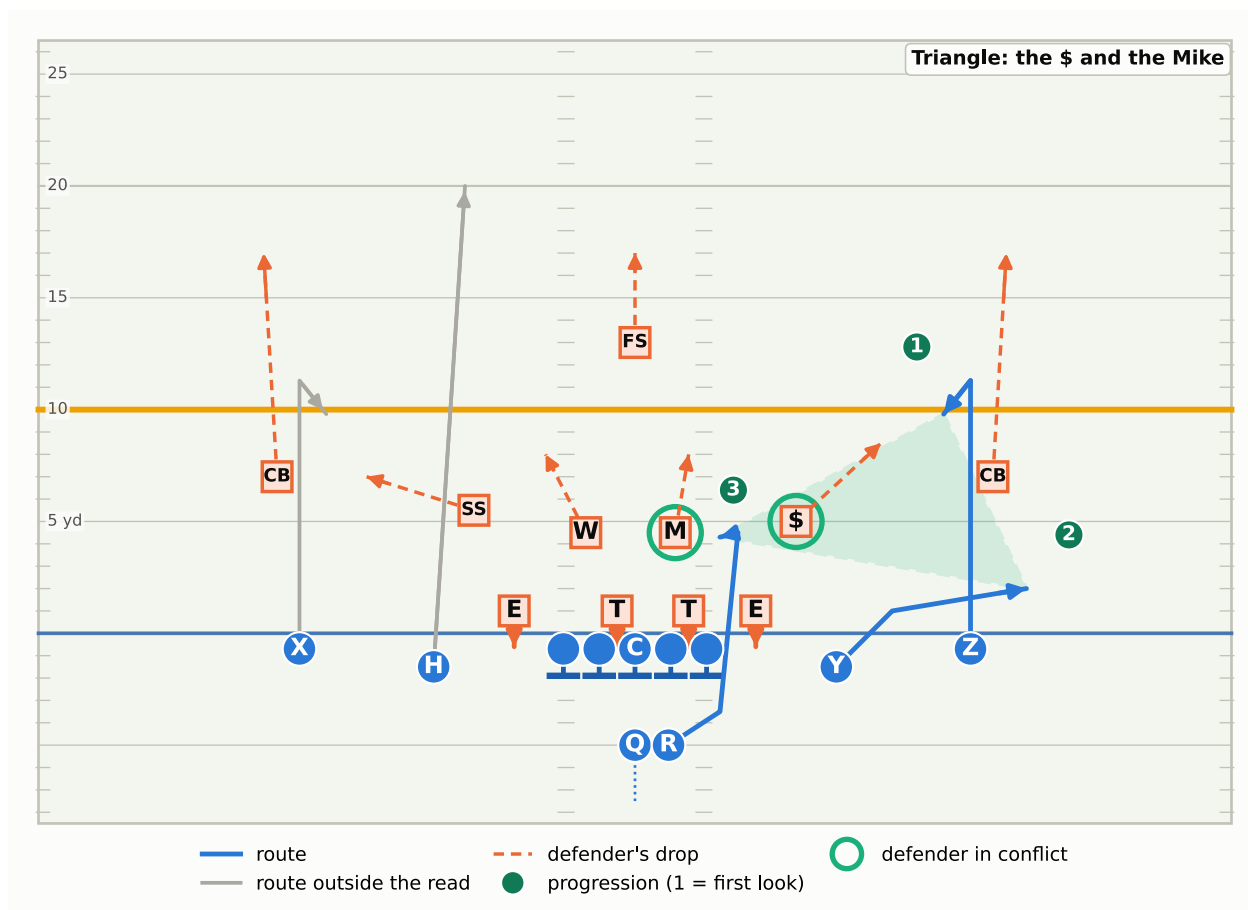


Figure 4: Curl-flat to the offense's right, with the back's hook route inside, against Cover 3. Z runs a curl at 12 yards, Y runs to the flat, and the back checks for a blitz, then settles at five yards over the right tackle. The three routes form a triangle (shaded) around two defenders: the ringed nickel (\$), who guards the curl-flat area, and the Mike (M), who guards the hook. The progression: (1) the curl, if the \$ widens to the flat; (2) the flat, if he sinks under the curl; (3) the hook, if both of them get width or depth. The left side runs a mirror-image curl and a seam (grey).

The triangle is what makes the concept durable. The nickel can't cover the curl and the flat (that's the high-low), and if he splits the difference, the Mike has to choose between helping on the curl and standing on the hook (that's the in-out). The quarterback reads it with the same rhythm on almost every snap: eyes to the curl as his back foot lands, then down to the flat, then inside to the hook. The routes are short enough that the ball comes out in under three seconds, which is why curl-flat sits at the border between the quick game and the dropback game.

Curl-flat is a West Coast staple, the family of offenses descended from Bill Walsh's 49ers, which were built on high-percentage throws with a third receiver underneath as the safety valve. Its weakness is its depth. Every route in the triangle is within 12 yards of the line of scrimmage, so a defense that squeezes the short zones and tackles well can hold it to a five-yard gain; and against two-high coverages, whose cornerbacks often sit short and outside, the curl can find a defender standing right on top of it.

Vertical stretches in the middle: levels, drive, shallow cross and dagger

The next four concepts carry the high-low into the middle of the field, where the linebackers live. The middle is harder to throw into (there are more defenders there, and they are closer together) but it's also the most valuable area on the field, as the chart at the end of this section shows. The defender in conflict in each of these concepts is a linebacker, or a safety standing behind the linebackers, and the routes are mostly in-breakers: digs, shallow crosses and in routes that run across his face.

Levels: two in-breakers, two depths

Levels sends two receivers from the same side across the field on in-breaking routes at two depths: the inside receiver at about five yards, the outside receiver on a dig at about twelve. The defender between those levels is the linebacker guarding the hook area on that side.

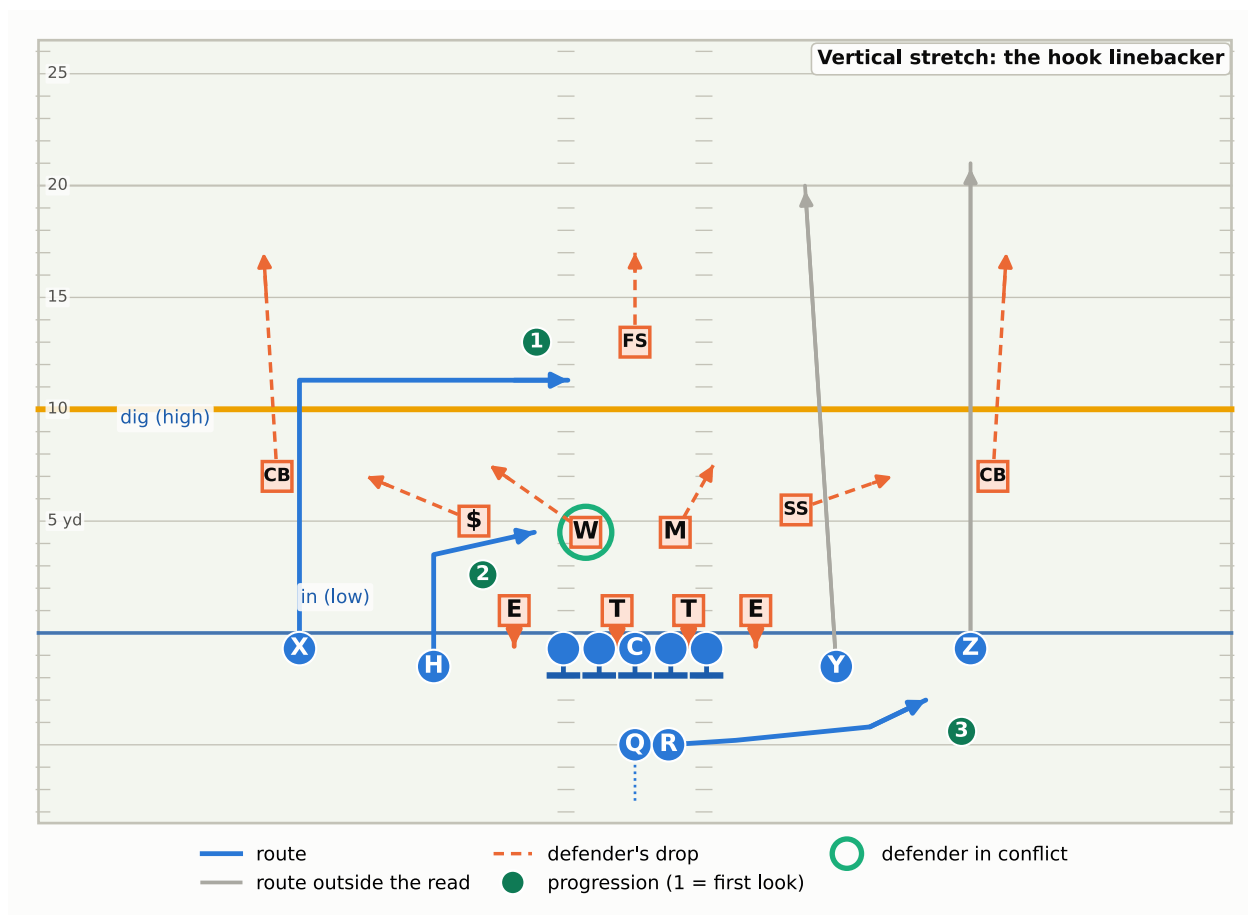


Figure 5: Levels to the offense's left against Cover 3. X runs a dig at 12 yards, H a shallow in route at 5 yards underneath him. The ringed Will linebacker (W), who drops to the hook area on that side, is the man in conflict: (1) the dig if he jumps the short in route; (2) the in route if he drops under the dig; (3) the back, who checks for a blitz, then releases to the flat on the right. On the right, Y's seam and Z's go route (grey) keep the free safety in the middle and the cornerback deep.

Why in-breakers? Because the linebacker in the middle is usually watching the quarterback, not the receivers, and he drops *backward*, which makes him slow to react to a route crossing in front of him or behind him. The short in route arrives first; the dig arrives a beat later, behind him. Coaches teach the quarterback to look high first: if the linebacker comes up on the in route, the dig behind him is the bigger gain. Peyton Manning's Indianapolis offenses made levels one of their signature calls, and its logic, two in-breakers on two floors, runs through many of the middle-of-the-field concepts that follow.²

Drive: the shallow and the dig, together

Drive is levels stretched across the whole field. One receiver runs a shallow cross, two to four yards deep, all the way to the far side; a teammate from the same side runs a dig at about twelve yards behind him, following him across. The pair passes through the hook zones of both linebackers.

²Chris B. Brown, *The Essential Smart Football* (2012), and his Smart Football essays on the Colts' passing game under offensive coordinator Tom Moore, in which levels was a staple.

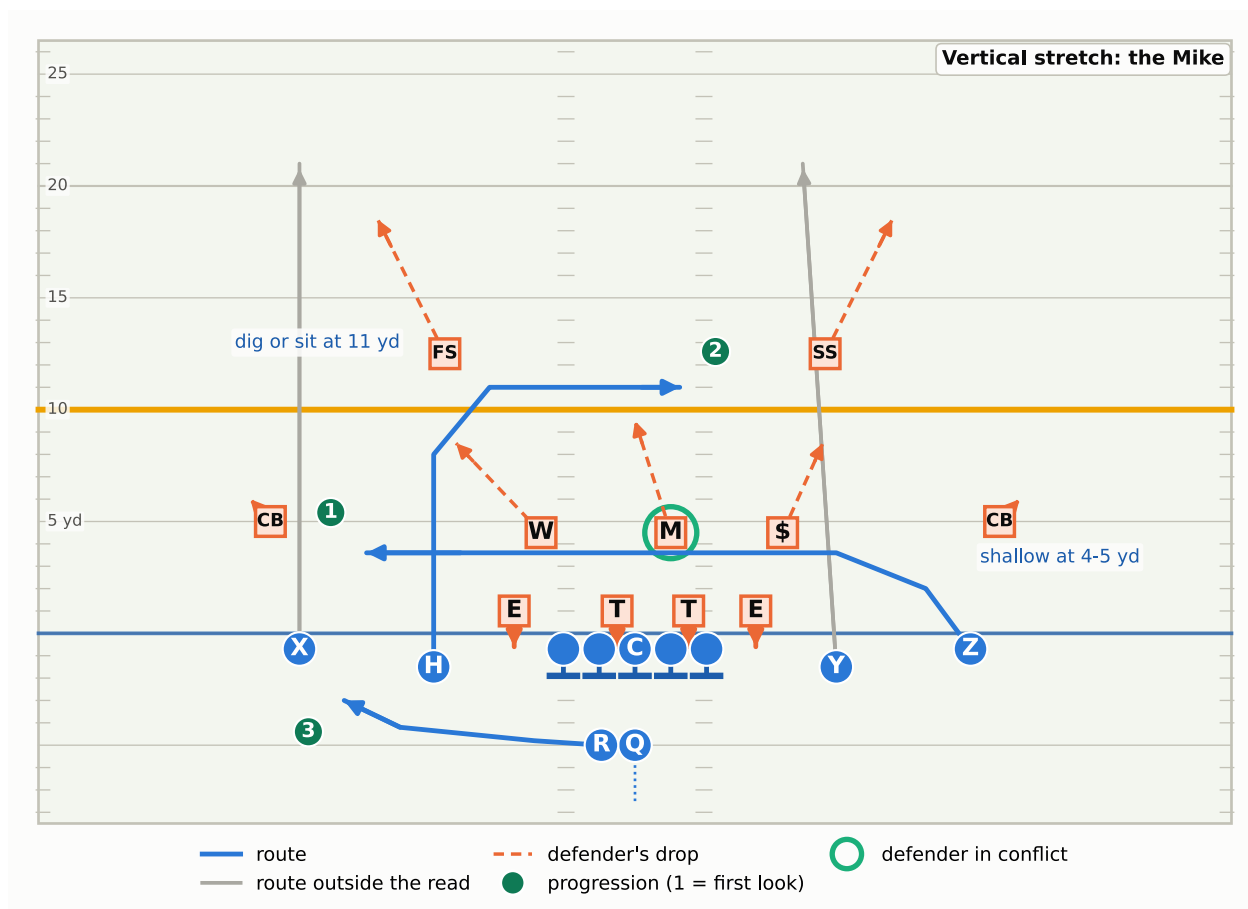


Figure 7: Shallow cross against Cover 2. From the right, Z runs a shallow cross at about five yards to the left; from the left, H runs a dig that settles at 11 yards over the ball. The ringed Mike (M), dropping into the middle, is the read: (1) the shallow, if he sinks; (2) the dig, if he comes up for the shallow; (3) the back on the left as the checkdown. X and Y (grey) run vertically to hold the two safeties, so nobody sinks under the dig from above. Against man coverage, the shallow simply runs away from his defender, and the two crossing paths add traffic.

The shallow cross is the play most associated with the Air Raid, the pass-first college offense built by Hal Mumme and Mike Leach (its story is below), which ran it with wide line splits and a quarterback taught to throw the shallow the instant the linebacker dropped. It works for the same reason drive does, plus one more: because the two crossers come from opposite sides, a man defender chasing the shallow may have to run around the dig receiver coming the other way. That is the first appearance of an idea we'll make explicit with mesh, the rub.

Dagger: clear the seam, fill it behind

Dagger is the deep member of the family, and the one built to beat two-high coverages. The inside receiver runs straight up the seam; the outside receiver runs a deep dig, 15 to 18 yards, coming in behind him.

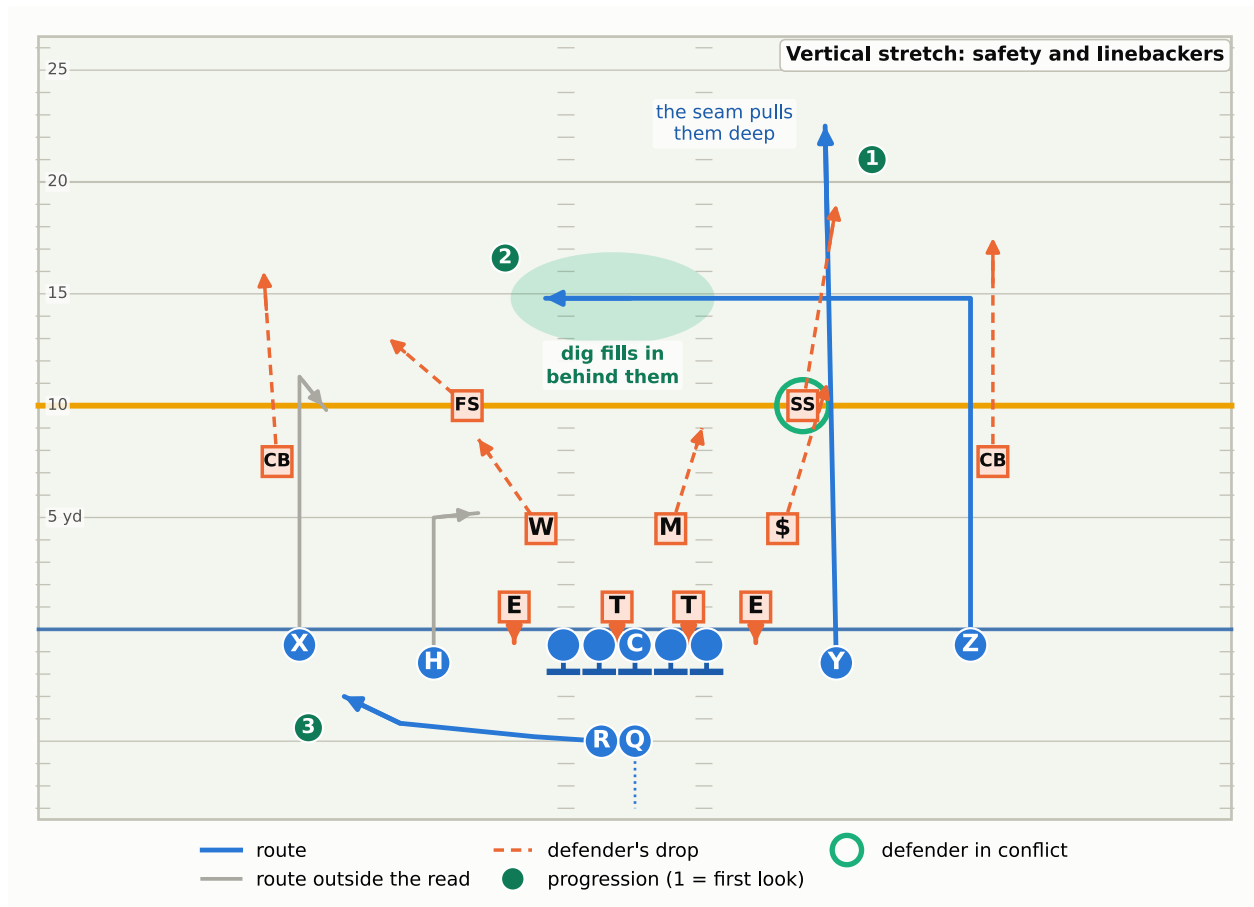


Figure 8: Dagger to the offense's right against Quarters. Y runs straight up the seam; Z runs a dig at about 16 yards, in behind him. The ringed strong safety (SS) is reading Y, the second receiver from the sideline, as Quarters tells him to, so the seam pulls him deep, and the nickel and Mike sink with it; the dig arrives in the space they vacate, under the safeties and over the linebackers. The progression: (1) the seam, if the safety doesn't carry it; (2) the dig; (3) the back, the checkdown on the left. On the left, X and H run routes (grey) that keep the free safety from drifting over.

Why would two-high coverages be vulnerable to this? In Quarters and its relatives, each safety reads the inside receiver on his side: if that receiver goes vertical, the safety takes him deep. That rule is what makes Quarters so good against the run and the quick game, because the safety can come up hard on anything short. Dagger turns the rule against him. The seam pulls the safety deep and drags the underneath defenders back with it, and the dig, timed to arrive a beat later, settles in the empty middle between the levels. Against one-high coverage the read is similar but the threat is different: the seam attacks the single safety, and if he stays in the middle, the dig crosses under him. Dagger needs time, because a 16-yard dig takes a deep drop and three seconds or more, which is why it's usually called with six- or seven-man protection.

Where the value is

Why do offenses work so hard to throw into the middle, where the linebackers are, rather than to the open sideline? The chart answers that with three seasons of throws.

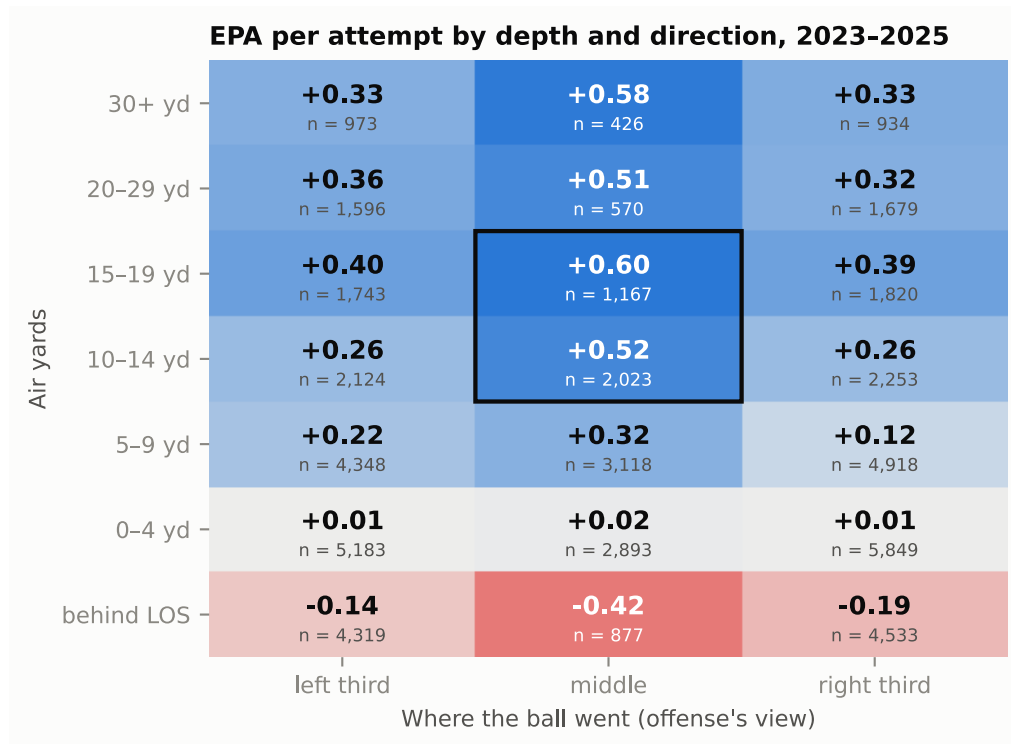


Figure 9: Expected points added (EPA) per pass attempt by where the ball was thrown, 2023–2025 regular seasons: rows are depth past the line of scrimmage (air yards), columns are the play-by-play charter’s left, middle and right thirds of the field. Blue cells added value on average, red cells lost it; the small number is the count of attempts. The intermediate middle (10–20 yards between the hashes, where levels, drive, shallow cross, dagger and Y-cross throw) is the most valuable area on the field per attempt, worth half a point or more. Deep throws are valuable everywhere but rarer; throws behind the line lose value on average. Sacks and spikes are excluded; interceptions count against the cell they were thrown to.

The boxed cells are the payoff. Over three seasons, a throw of 10 to 19 yards into the middle of the field added about half an expected point on average, more than the same depth toward either sideline and more than any short throw anywhere.³ Two cautions keep the chart honest. First, it shows where the ball *went*, not where the quarterback *wanted* it to go: quarterbacks throw into the middle when somebody is open there, so the cells partly measure good decisions. Second, the middle is also where interceptions happen (the defenders are closer together), and those are already folded into the averages. Even so, the shape explains a great deal of offensive design: the intermediate middle is worth fighting for, and the concepts in this section are the tools for getting there.

Y-cross: a flood built from across the field

Y-cross combines the two ideas so far, the three-level flood and the in-breaker through the middle. A receiver from one side (in the Air Raid’s lettering, the Y, the inside receiver) runs a crossing route that climbs to 15 or 18 yards as it goes and finishes near the far sideline. On that far side, the outside receiver runs a go route to clear the cornerback away and another receiver runs to the flat. The result is a flood whose middle level arrives from the other side of the field, at full speed, where no defender on that side was looking for it.

³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2023–2025 regular seasons: 53,346 pass attempts with charted air yards and direction (`pass_location`: left, middle, right), sacks and spikes excluded. Throws of 10–14 air yards to the middle averaged +0.52 EPA (n = 2,023) and 15–19 yards +0.60 (n = 1,167), against +0.26 and +0.39–0.40 to the outside thirds at the same depths. The charter’s “middle” is roughly the area between the hash marks; it is a judgment call, not a measured coordinate.

i Go deeper: the Air Raid's small menu

The Air Raid was built at small colleges, not in the NFL. Hal Mumme, a high school and small college coach, and Mike Leach, a former law student who had never played college football, put it together at Iowa Wesleyan around 1989, took it to Valdosta State and then, in 1997, to the University of Kentucky, where quarterback Tim Couch became the first pick of the 1999 NFL draft. Leach went on to run it as a head coach at Texas Tech, Washington State and Mississippi State.⁴

Their starting point was the passing game of LaVell Edwards's BYU teams, which they studied in person, and their central idea was subtraction: run a handful of concepts (mesh, shallow cross, Y-cross, four verticals, a few quick-game calls) from a handful of formations, and practice them so many times that the quarterback and receivers react instead of think. Where an NFL playbook might carry hundreds of pass plays, the Air Raid lived on a dozen. Its lesson for this chapter is that a concept's power comes as much from repetition as from design: a quarterback who has read the same curl-flat defender on the same Y-cross ten thousand times throws the ball before the defender has finished deciding. The full story of the Air Raid's spread through college and then the NFL is told in *The College Laboratory*.

Man-beaters: mesh, the rub and the angle route

Everything so far is built to beat zone defenders, who guard areas and can be put between two receivers. Man coverage changes the problem. Each defender has one receiver and follows him, so there is no area to overload and no defender in two minds; the defense is betting its players can stay with yours. The answer is to make *staying with* a receiver hard: send receivers across the field, where their defenders have to chase them through traffic; break away from a defender's leverage; or find a defender who is badly matched against the man he has to cover.

Mesh

Mesh is the purest man-beater in football. Two receivers from opposite sides run shallow crossing routes, five or six yards deep, that pass within a yard or two of each other over the middle of the field. One runs his cross a step higher than the other, and Air Raid coaches tell them to pass close enough to slap hands.

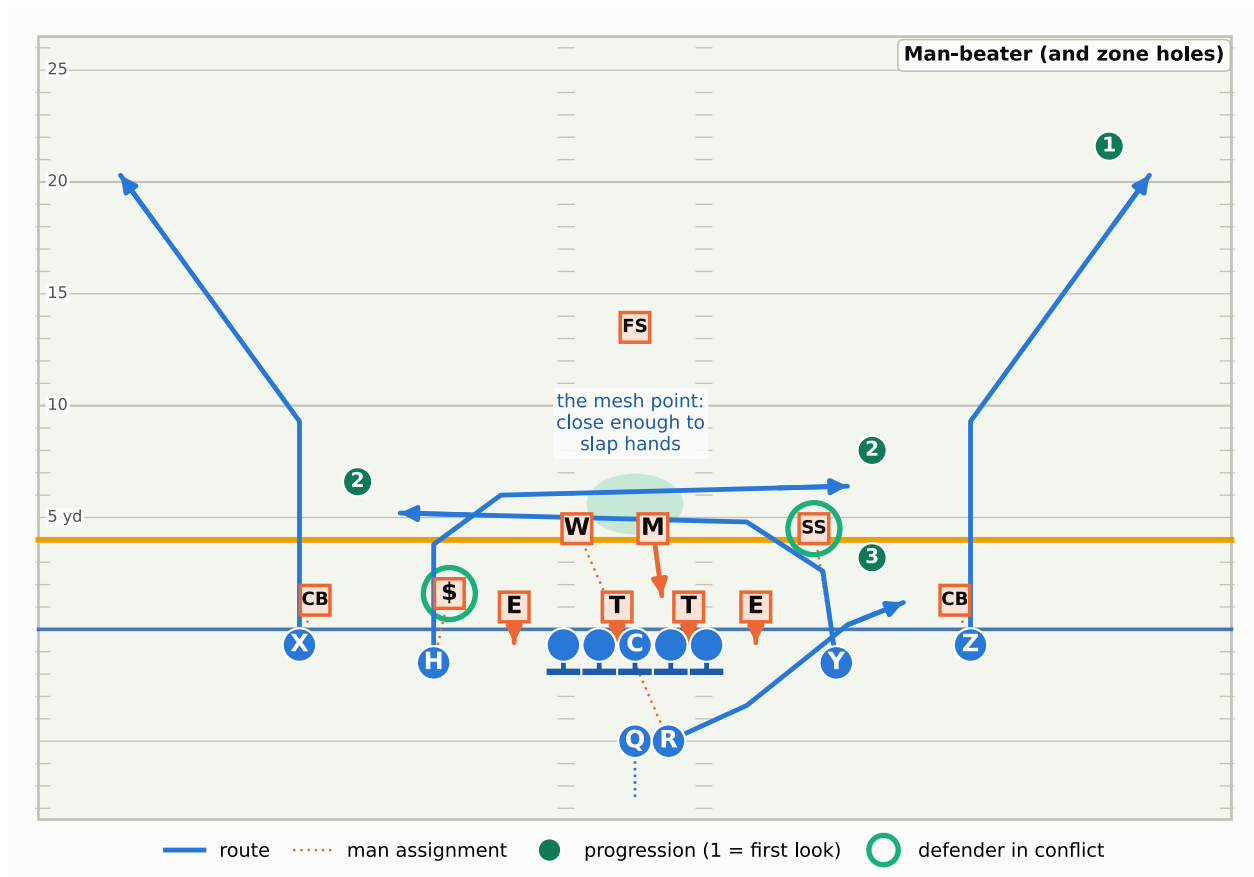


Figure 11: Mesh against Cover 1 (man coverage with one deep safety), the version run by the Air Raid. H and Y cross at five to six yards over the ball, H a step above Y, so the defenders chasing them, the nickel (\$) and the strong safety (SS), both ringed, have to get around one receiver to stay with the other. X and Z run corner routes and the back runs to the right flat. The progression in the traditional Air Raid order: (1) the corner route to the back's side, over the back's flat route; (2) the crossers, whichever comes out of the traffic first; (3) the back. Against man coverage, many teams look to the crossers first. Dotted lines are man assignments; the Mike rushes.

Against man coverage the two crossing paths do the work. The nickel chasing H has to get past Y coming the other way, and the safety chasing Y has to get past H. One of them almost always loses a step, and a receiver crossing the field with a one-step lead is nearly impossible to catch from behind. Against zone the same routes simply settle: each crosser finds the space between two underneath defenders and sits down facing the quarterback, so the concept is useful even when the defense guesses right. The corner routes give the quarterback a high-low against the cornerbacks, and keep the safety from crowding the middle.

Mesh came into the Air Raid from BYU and became its signature play; versions of it now appear in every NFL playbook, often as a third-down call, when defenses play the most man coverage.

The rub, and where it becomes a pick

Mesh works because of a specific kind of route. A **rub route** (also called a **pick route**) is a route designed to cross close to a teammate's route, so a defender chasing one receiver has to go around the other. Crossers, stacked receivers who release in opposite directions, and a slot receiver running a quick out under an outside receiver's slant are all rubs. They are among the most effective plays in football against man coverage, especially near the goal line, where the field is short and defenders play tight.

They are also the most argued-about. The rules allow a receiver to run his route even if a defender runs into him. They don't allow him to *block* a defender downfield before the ball is thrown and touched. In the NFL, a receiver who deliberately makes contact with a defender more than one yard past the line of scrimmage to get a teammate open, before the pass is touched, has committed

⁵NFL Rulebook, Rule 8, Section 5 (pass interference): offensive pass interference rules apply from the snap until the ball is touched, and include blocking downfield by an offensive player before the ball is touched; contact within one yard of the line of scrimmage is not offensive pass interference. The penalty is 10 yards from the previous spot. <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. Enforcement and how often it is called: Contact Rules and Penalties.

offensive pass interference, a 10-yard penalty; contact within a yard of the line is allowed.⁵ That is the line between a rub and an illegal pick.

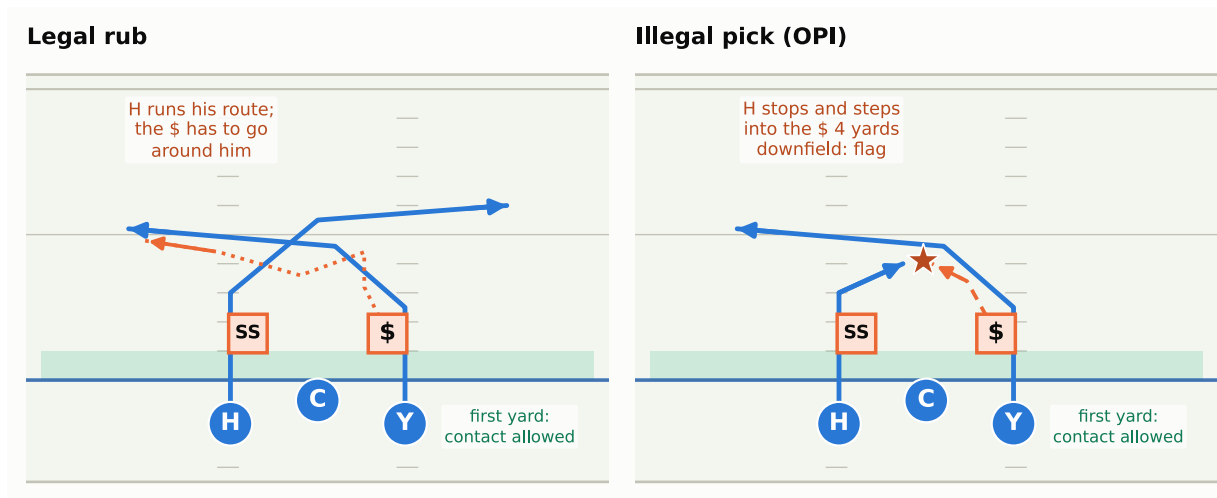


Figure 12: The same two routes, legal and illegal. Left: a legal rub. H runs his crossing route without breaking stride; the defender chasing Y has to go around him (dotted orange), loses a step, and Y comes free. No one blocked anybody. Right: an illegal pick. H stops his route four yards downfield, turns, and steps into Y's defender before the ball is thrown: that is offensive pass interference. The green band is the first yard past the line of scrimmage, where contact between receivers and defenders is allowed in the NFL.

The trouble is that the difference is often a matter of intent and inches, and officials have to judge it at full speed. Offenses teach receivers to run through the defender's path rather than at him, and to keep running; defenses teach their players to communicate ("switch" or "banjo," trading receivers instead of chasing through the traffic, which Man Coverage explains) or to play zone, against which rubs gain nothing. How the officials enforce pass interference, and how often they call it, is in Contact Rules and Penalties.

Here is mesh against man coverage, moving. Watch the strong safety chasing Y.

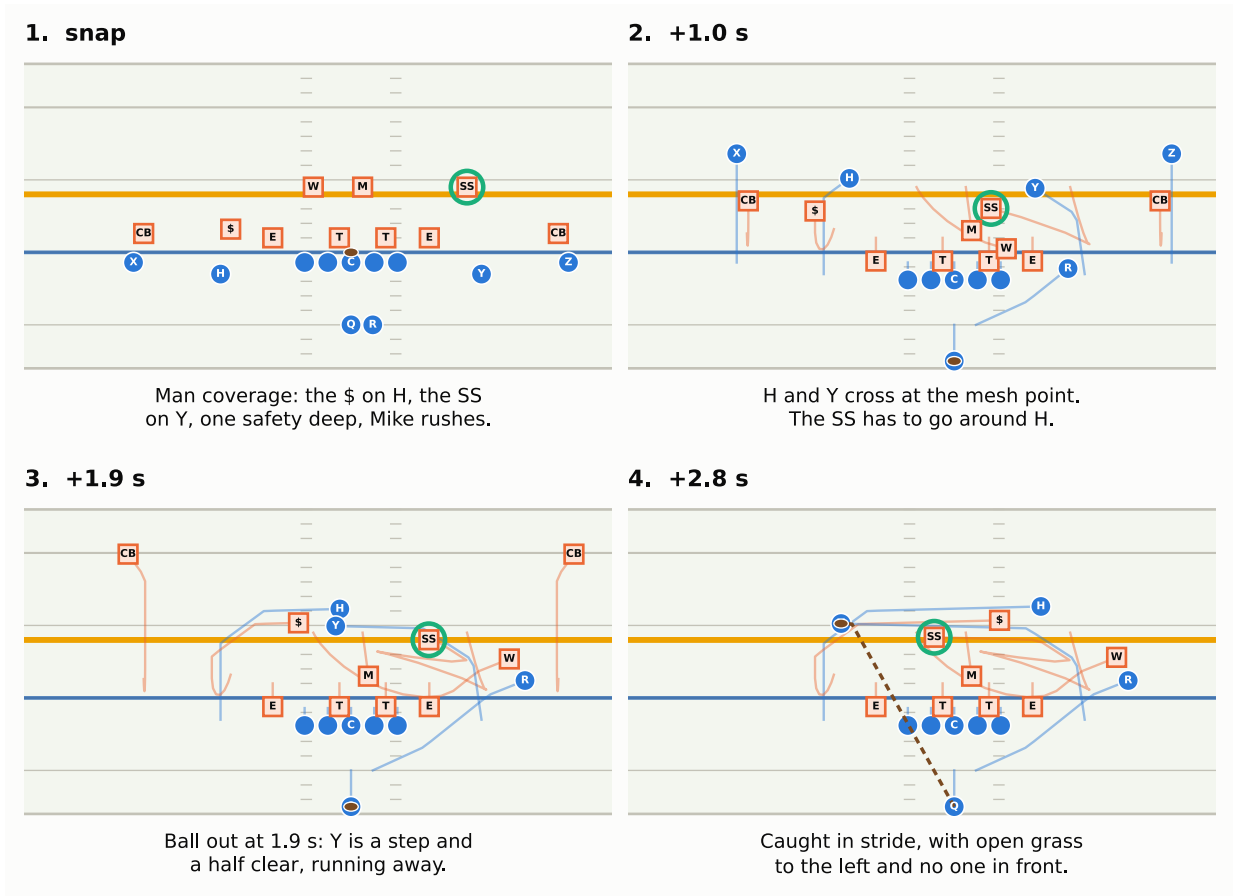


Figure 13: Mesh against Cover 1, simulated (BDB-format tracking, generated by gridiron rather than recorded). H and Y cross at about five yards over the ball. The nickel (\$) trails H on his hip; the strong safety (SS, ringed), chasing Y, has to go around H, and by the time he is through, Y has a two-yard lead running away from him. The ball is out at about 1.9 seconds to Y, crossing toward the open left side of the field, before the deep safety can come down. Faint lines are where each player has been; the brown dashes are the ball in flight.

The angle route: a running back against a linebacker

The other classic man-beater uses a mismatch instead of traffic. In man coverage, somebody has to cover the running back, and it is usually a linebacker: a player chosen for stopping runs, often thirty pounds heavier than the back and a step slower in space. The **angle route** (many playbooks call it the **Texas route**) is built for that matchup. The back releases toward the flat as if running a swing, and when the linebacker widens to chase him, he plants and snaps back inside, angling upfield under the middle of the field.

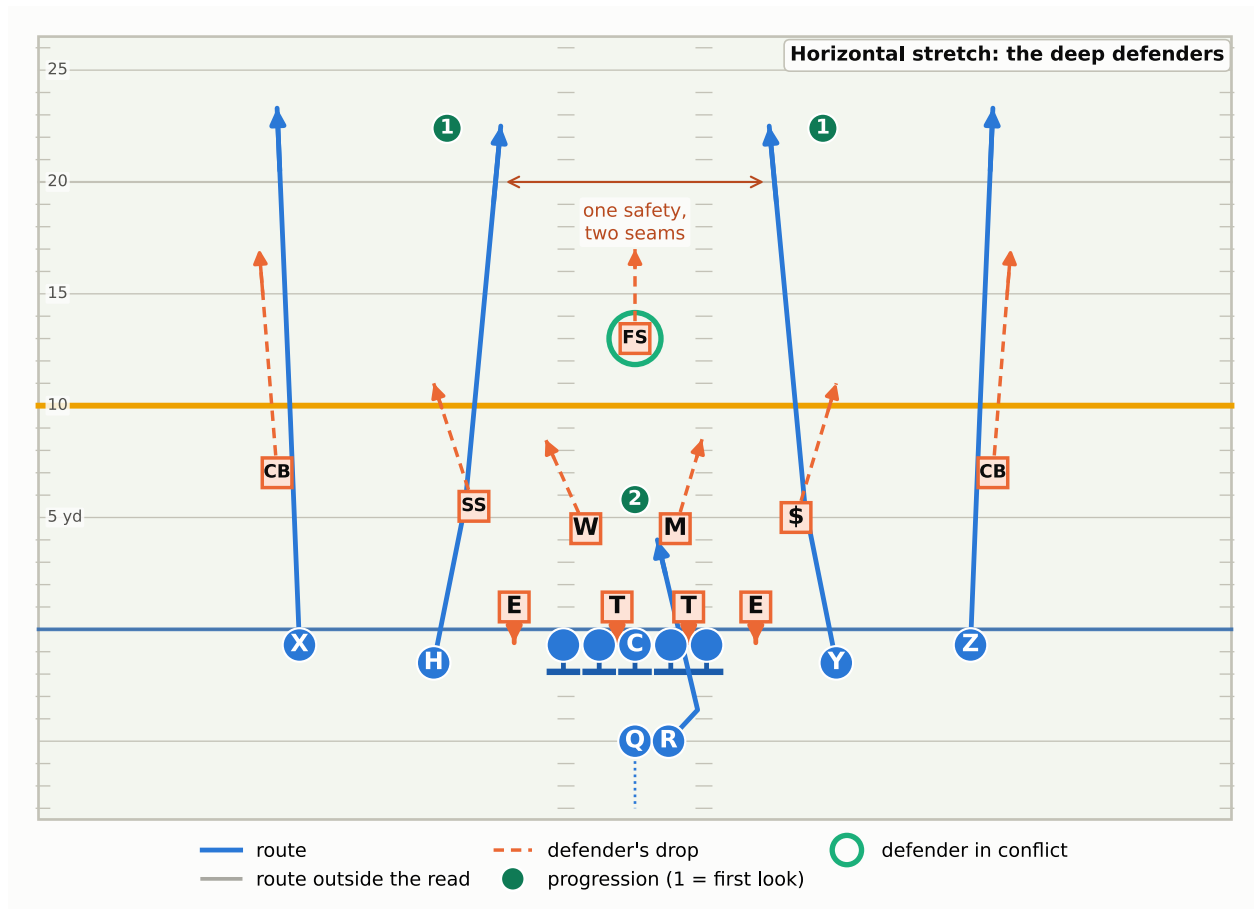


Figure 15: Four verticals against Cover 3. X and Z run go routes outside the numbers; H and Y run up the seams just outside the hashes. Three deep defenders face four vertical routes: the cornerbacks have the outside receivers in their deep thirds, so the ringed free safety, alone in the middle third, has two seams to cover. The progression: (1) the seam he doesn't take, read from his first steps; (2) the back, who checks for a blitz and then settles over the ball, if the curl-flat defenders sink with the seams. The outside go routes are the first look only against a cornerback who sits short, as in Cover 2.

The arithmetic is the point. Against Cover 3, three deep defenders divide the field into thirds; four vertical routes put two receivers in the middle third, where there is only one defender. If he leans toward one seam, the quarterback throws the other. Against Cover 2, with two deep safeties each guarding a half, the seams split the safeties and the outside receivers attack the gap between the squatting cornerbacks and the safeties along the sideline, the same hole smash attacks. The concept forces the deep defenders to show where they are, and the quarterback reads them, not the underneath ones.

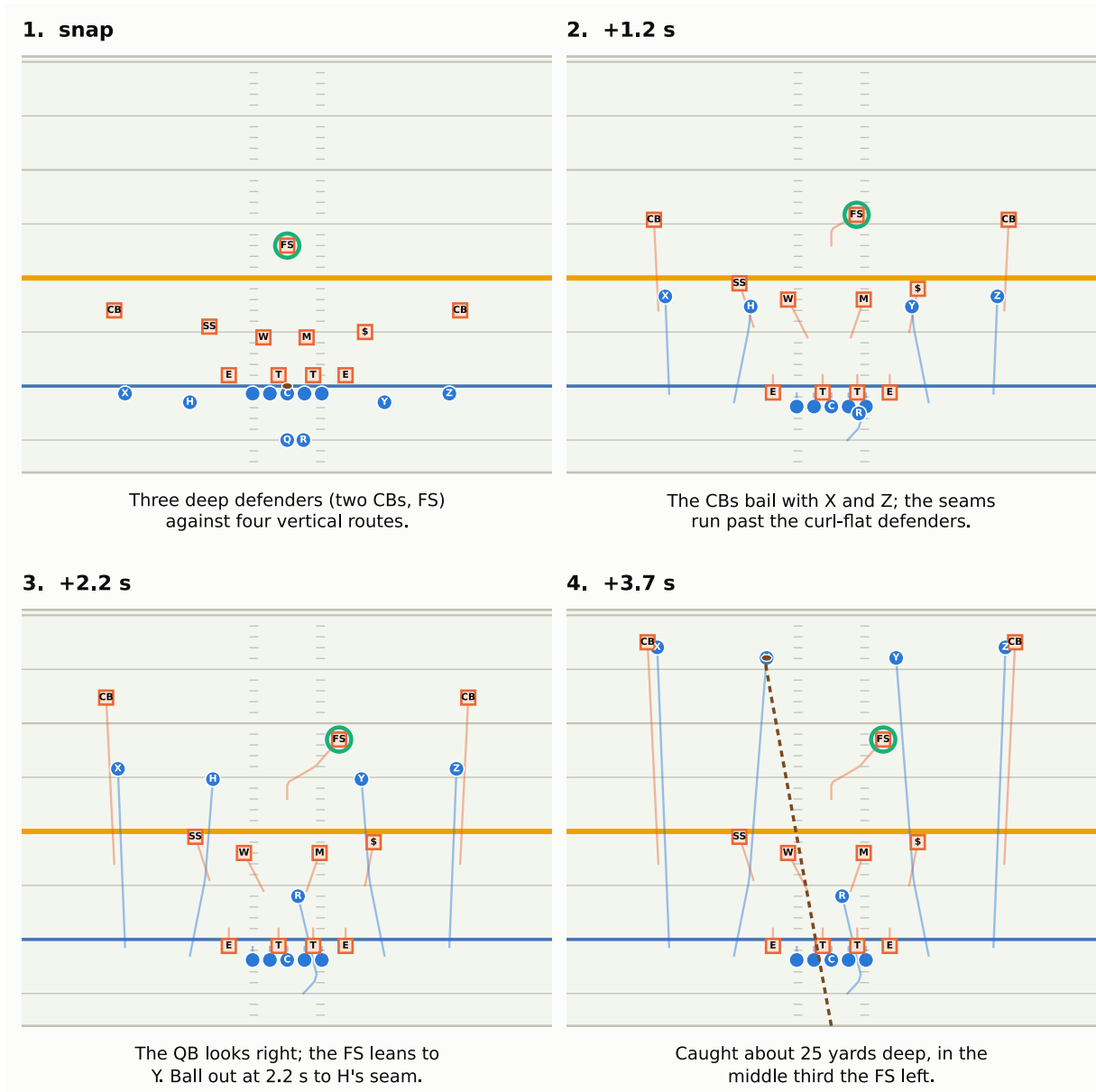


Figure 16: Four verticals against Cover 3, simulated (BDB-format tracking, generated by gridiron). The cornerbacks bail with the outside receivers, the curl-flat defenders run with the seams for a few steps and then let them go, and the free safety (ringed) has to choose. The quarterback looks to his right as he drops, and the safety drifts that way, toward Y; the ball goes to H on the left seam, behind the curl-flat defender and in front of the cornerback, about 20 yards downfield.

Notice what the quarterback did with his eyes. He looked toward Y as he dropped, and the safety, who reads the quarterback, drifted that way. Moving a defender with your eyes is called a look-off, and it's an essential skill for any concept that reads a single deep defender (Quarterback Play has more).

Four verticals goes back at least to the 1970s and 1980s, when BYU, Don Coryell's San Diego Chargers and the run-and-shoot offenses of Mouse Davis all built passing games around vertical routes; the Air Raid made it one of its core calls. In the modern NFL it rarely looks like four straight lines. Andy Reid's Chiefs, for one, have run many variations, with Travis Kelce on a seam route that bends inside or holds straight depending on the safeties (a route conversion, as below) and speed outside to stretch the cornerbacks.

Post-wheel

Post-wheel stretches the deep defender on one side, inside and out. The outside receiver runs a post, angling toward the middle at about 12 yards; the inside receiver (or a back) runs a wheel, out toward the flat and then straight up the sideline, into the space the post receiver just left.

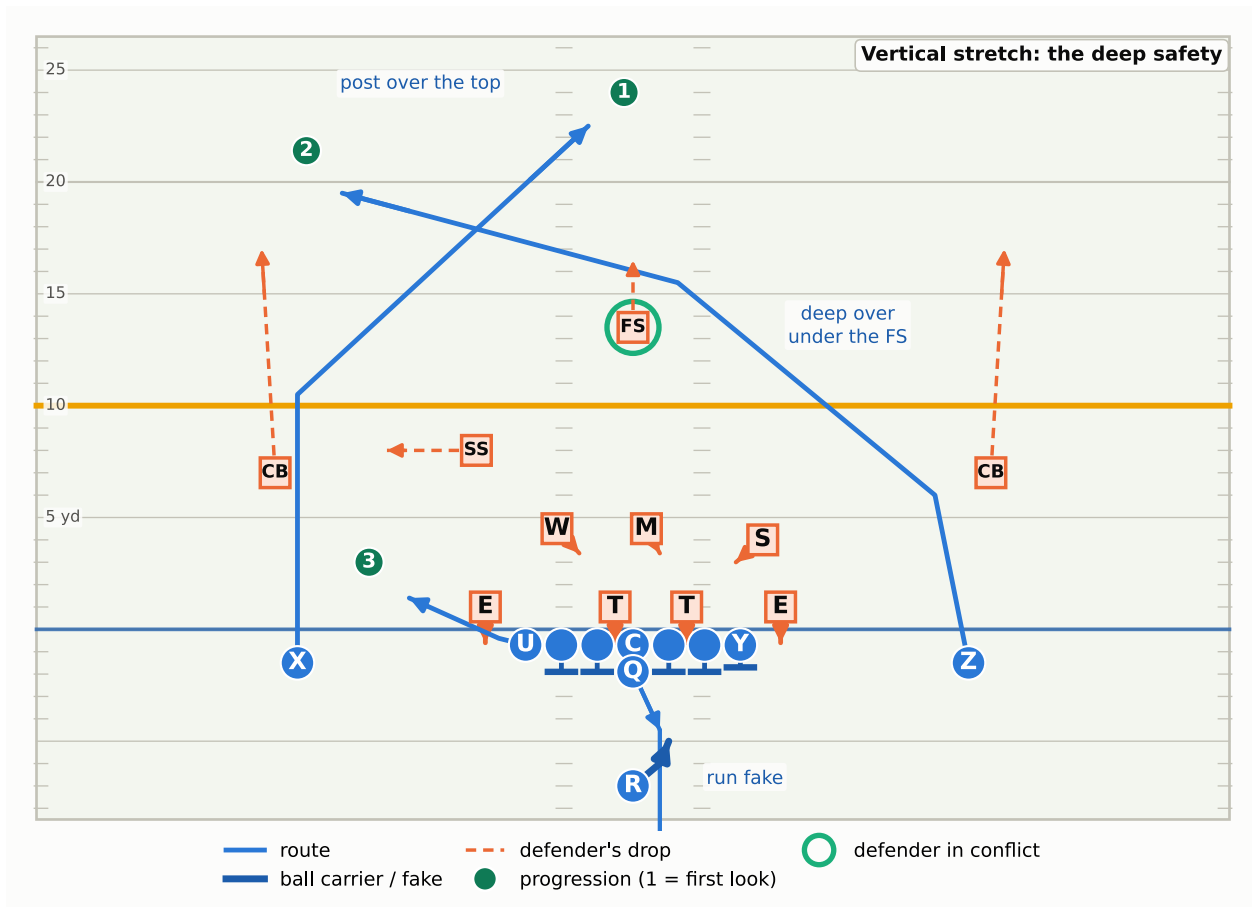


Figure 19: Yankee against Cover 3, from an under-center formation with two tight ends (12 personnel). The quarterback fakes a handoff to the back (R), then sets up deep. X runs a post from the left; Z runs a deep over from the right, climbing to about 20 yards. The ringed free safety, alone in the deep middle, faces a high-low: (1) the post if he comes up on the over; (2) the over if he stays deep with the post. The back, both tight ends and the five linemen block (seven-man protection); U releases late to the flat as the outlet (3). The linebackers step up toward the run fake (short orange arrows), which empties the area the over route crosses.

Why does it work? The run fake does half the job. Linebackers are taught to stop the run first, so they step forward when they see a handoff, and that step takes them out of the path of the deep over, which crosses behind them at a depth no underneath defender can reach. The other half is a high-low on the one man left: the free safety in the middle of the field can sink to take away the post or come forward to take away the over, not both. Sean McVay's Rams made yankee one of the signature shot plays of the late 2010s, and it now appears in most NFL playbooks that come from the Shanahan and McVay family of offenses. The price is the protection: with seven or eight blockers, only two or three receivers go out, so if the safety plays it perfectly the quarterback has very little to throw to. The name of the play-action game, and why the fake works even when the run game doesn't, belong to Play-Action, Bootlegs, and Screens.

Tags and route conversions

Fourteen concepts sounds like a lot, but a real playbook has many more, and most of the extras aren't new concepts at all. They are the same concepts with a word added. A tag is a word added to a play call that changes one player's assignment and leaves everyone else's alone. "Mesh" tells all five receivers what to do; "Mesh, Z-wheel" keeps mesh intact except for Z, who runs a wheel instead of his corner route. Tags let a play-caller adjust a concept to a defense's habits (a cornerback who jumps corner routes, a safety who cheats toward the crossers) without teaching a new play.

The second tool is subtler, and it explains how one call can be right against several coverages. A **route conversion** is a rule built into a route that changes it according to the coverage the receiver sees. The receiver doesn't wait for the quarterback to tell him; he reads the defense himself, usually the safeties, and the quarterback, reading the same thing, knows where he will be.

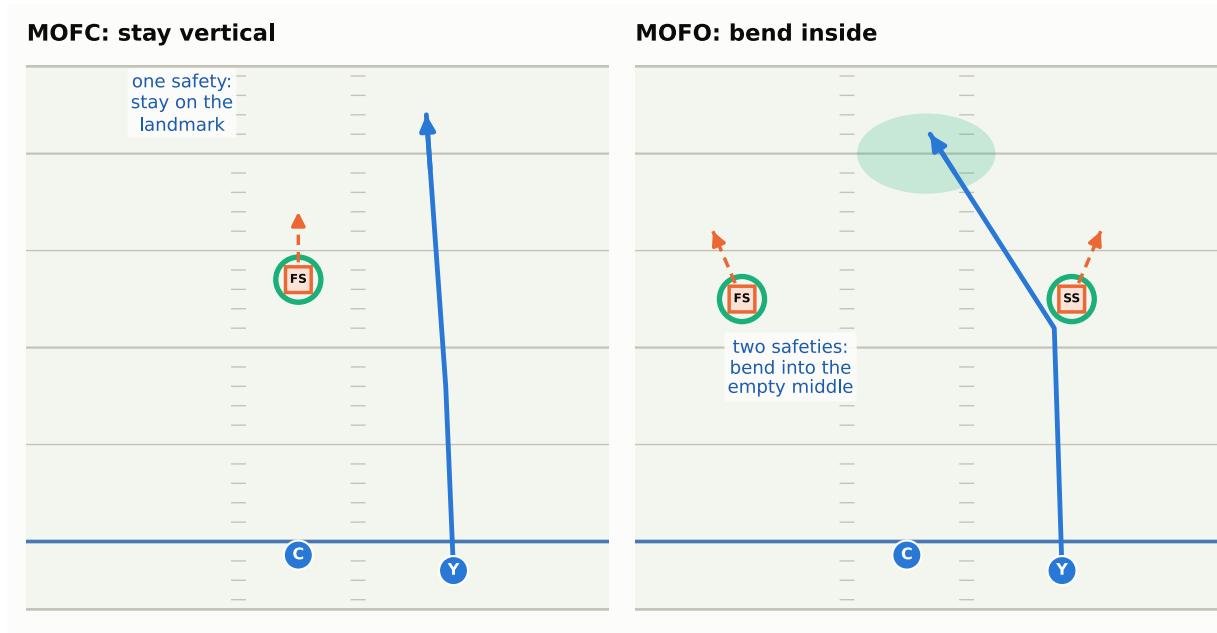


Figure 20: One route conversion: the seam route in four verticals. The receiver (Y) reads the safeties as he runs. Left, middle of the field closed (one deep safety): he stays on his landmark just outside the hash and bends slightly away from the safety, keeping him in conflict with the other seam. Right, middle of the field open (two deep safeties): the middle is empty, so at about 12 yards he bends inside, splitting the safeties, into the space between them (green). Same call, same receiver; the coverage picks the route.

You’ve already met the most important conversion. The option route of Passing Fundamentals, which some systems call the *choice route*, is a conversion with two branches: against man, break away from the defender’s leverage; against zone, sit in the hole. Others are everywhere in this chapter. The smash corner route flattens under a two-high safety and pushes deeper against one-high. The levels and mesh crossers keep running against man and settle against zone. The dagger dig sits down in a window against zone and keeps crossing against man.

The Patriots of the Tom Brady era were the model of an offense built on conversions. Their Erhardt-Perkins system (named for Ron Erhardt and Ray Perkins, who coached together on New England’s staff in the 1970s, and carried forward by Bill Parcells to Bill Belichick and Josh McDaniels) named whole concepts with short words, so a quarterback could call them at the line, and gave its slot receivers wide freedom to read and adjust their routes after the snap.⁶ That’s why New England’s passing game seemed to have an answer for every defense without a thousand plays: the same few concepts, each with branches. The system’s history and its rivals are in Offensive Systems and Languages.

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game, the receiver runs the route drawn on the play art, whatever the defense does, and you press a button for the one you want. In the NFL, a large share of routes are conditional: the receiver converts the route against the coverage, the quarterback has to read the same thing and throw to where the receiver *will* be, and a mismatch between their reads is one of the commonest causes of an interception that looks, on the broadcast, like the quarterback threw to nobody. When an announcer says a receiver and quarterback “weren’t on the same page,” that’s usually what happened: one of them saw man and the other saw zone.

The quarterback’s side: one clock for every concept

Each plate in this chapter carried a progression, and they all follow the same pattern. That pattern is the real skill of dropback passing, so it is worth spelling out.

Before the snap, the quarterback identifies the shell (one high safety or two), checks the leverage of the defenders over the receivers in the concept, and asks the question every concept poses: *who is the defender in conflict, and where is he?* If the concept

⁶Chris B. Brown, *The Essential Smart Football* (2012), on the Erhardt-Perkins system and its one-word concept names; Ron Erhardt and Ray Perkins were assistants together on Chuck Fairbanks’s New England staff in the 1970s, and Bill Parcells used the system with the Giants and passed it to his assistants, including Bill Belichick. Josh McDaniels was New England’s offensive coordinator for most of Brady’s tenure (2006–2008 and 2012–2021).

is called to both sides, as smash often is, this is when he picks the side. If the defense shows a blitz, he checks the protection and his hot route (Pass Protection).

At the snap, his eyes go to the conflict defender, not to a receiver. His drop is timed so that the first read is ready as his back foot lands: on smash, the corner route breaks as he hits the bottom of his drop; on dagger, the dig arrives a beat later, which is why dagger takes a deeper drop or a hitch step.

After the first look, he moves to the next read with his feet as well as his eyes. Each *hitch*, a short step up into the pocket, resets his feet for the next throw. A typical dropback progression gets two or three looks before the rush arrives; the last is the checkdown, the short throw to a back that keeps the play from losing yards. As Passing Fundamentals showed with FTN's charting, more than half of all throws go to the first read, and those are the quickest and most valuable: the concept is at its best when its first answer is right.

High to low or low to high? Most vertical stretches are read from the top down: look at the deep route first, because if it's open it's the bigger gain, then come down to the short one, which will still be there. Some are read the other way: the drive shallow and the mesh crossers are looked at first against man, because a crosser who wins does so immediately. Coaches choose the order to fit the concept's timing and the down and distance. On third-and-8, a progression starts with the route that reaches the line to gain.

The table gathers the fourteen concepts, the family each belongs to, the defender it puts in a bind and the coverage it's built to beat. The last column is the subject of What Beats What, which pairs concepts with coverages in detail; how each coverage defends these concepts is in Part 6, beginning with Coverage Fundamentals and, for four verticals, The Cover 3 Family.

Table 1: The fourteen dropback concepts at a glance. "Built to beat" is the concept's best matchup, not its only one.

Concept	Family	Defender in conflict	Built to beat	Typical progression
Smash	Vertical stretch	Cornerback	Cover 2	corner → hitch → back
Flood (sail)	Vertical, three levels	Curl-flat defender	Cover 3	sail → flat (go if the corner sits)
Curl-flat	Triangle	Curl-flat and hook defenders	Cover 3, zone	curl → flat → hook
Levels	Vertical stretch	Hook linebacker	Zone	dig → in → back
Drive	Vertical; also a man-beater	Middle linebacker	Zone and man	shallow → dig → back
Shallow cross	Vertical; also a man-beater	Middle linebacker	Zone and man	shallow → dig or sit → back
Dagger	Vertical stretch	Safety and hook defenders	Two-high (Quarters, Cover 2)	seam → dig → back
Y-cross	Vertical, three levels	Far curl-flat defender	Cover 3, man	cross → flat → back
Mesh	Man-beater	Man defenders on the crossers	Man (Cover 1, Cover 0)	corner → crossers → back
Angle (Texas)	Man-beater	Linebacker covering the back	Man	angle → seam
Four verticals	Horizontal, deep	Free safety	Cover 3, Cover 2	seam away from the safety → back
Post-wheel	Horizontal, deep	Cornerback	Cover 3, man	wheel → post → back
Scissors	Horizontal, deep	Safety	Quarters	post → corner → back
Yankee	Vertical, deep	Free safety	One-high	post → over → outlet

Film room

The concepts above are in every NFL playbook. A few teams built an identity on them, and watching those teams is the fastest way to learn to see the concepts at game speed.

i Film room: Texas Tech 2007–2008

Mesh and Y-cross, rep after rep. Mike Leach's Texas Tech teams were the Air Raid at full volume. In 2007, quarterback Graham Harrell threw for 5,705 yards and freshman receiver Michael Crabtree caught 134 passes for 1,962 yards and 22 touchdowns; Crabtree won the Biletnikoff Award as the nation's best receiver that season and again in 2008.⁷ Nearly all of it came out of the same small menu of concepts drawn in this chapter: mesh, shallow cross, Y-cross and four verticals, from wide 2x2 and trips formations with enormous splits between the offensive linemen.

What to notice on the tape: the mesh point, two crossers passing over the center close enough to touch, and a defender losing a step as he goes around; Harrell's eyes on the curl-flat defender on Y-cross, and the ball arriving as the crosser came into the window; and how *few* different plays there were. The defense knew what was coming, and it didn't matter, because the offense had run each concept thousands of times against every look. Leach's former quarterback Kliff Kingsbury later brought the same concepts to the NFL as the Arizona Cardinals' head coach (2019–2022).⁸

i Film room: Los Angeles Rams 2018

Yankee and the play-action shot. In Sean McVay's second season, the Rams went 13–3 and reached Super Bowl LIII, where they lost to New England 13–3. Jared Goff threw for 4,688 yards and 32 touchdowns.⁹ Their passing game ran on a single foundation: line up in the same formation with three receivers, run outside-zone handoffs out of it, and throw play-action shots from the same look, yankee chief among them. On throws of 20 yards or more in the air, the Rams averaged about +0.77 EPA per attempt, third-best in the league, against a league average of about +0.37.¹⁰

What to notice on the tape: the linebackers' first step on the run fake, *toward* the line; the deep over crossing behind them at 18 to 20 yards; and the free safety in the middle, who has to decide between the over in front of him and the post behind him. Goff often had only two routes to choose from, and his decision was made by one defender.

i Film room: Kansas City Chiefs 2018

Four verticals with a 50-touchdown quarterback. In Patrick Mahomes's first season as the starter he threw for 5,097 yards and 50 touchdowns and was named the league's MVP. Andy Reid's offense threw deep more than almost anyone: 15% of the Chiefs' attempts traveled 20 yards or more in the air (fifth in the league; the league average was 12%), and those throws were worth about +0.75 EPA each, fourth best.¹¹ Tyreek Hill's speed outside and Travis Kelce up the seam made four verticals and its variants a constant threat.

What to notice on the tape: the deep defenders' first steps. With Hill on the outside, cornerbacks bailed at the snap, which opened everything underneath; with Kelce on a seam, the middle safety had to choose. Watch Kelce's seam bend or stay straight as he reads the safeties, the route conversion in action, and Mahomes moving the safety with his eyes before throwing the other way.

⁷Texas Tech Athletics and the NCAA record book: Graham Harrell, 5,705 passing yards in 2007; Michael Crabtree, 134 receptions, 1,962 yards and 22 touchdown catches in 2007, Biletnikoff Award winner in 2007 and 2008.

⁸Pro Football Reference, Kliff Kingsbury coaching record (Arizona Cardinals head coach, 2019–2022): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/KingKl0.htm>. Kingsbury played quarterback for Leach at Texas Tech (1999–2002).

⁹Pro Football Reference, 2018 Los Angeles Rams (13–3; lost Super Bowl LIII to New England, 13–3): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/ram/2018.htm>. Goff's 4,688 yards and 32 touchdowns also match nflverse play-by-play (course calculation).

¹⁰Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2018 regular season, pass attempts with sacks and spikes excluded. Throws of 20 or more air yards: league share 12.0%, EPA per attempt +0.37. Los Angeles Rams: 11.3% of attempts (18th of 32), +0.77 EPA (3rd).

¹¹Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2018 regular season, same filters: Kansas City threw 15.1% of its attempts 20 or more air yards (5th of 32) at +0.75 EPA per attempt (4th). Mahomes's 5,097 yards and 50 touchdown passes match Pro Football Reference and nflverse; he was the 2018 AP MVP: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/M/Mahopa00.htm>

Watch for it on Sunday

💡 Watch for it: name the concept

Before the snap

- **Find the shell.** One deep safety or two? Smash, dagger and scissors are two-high beaters; flood, four verticals, post-wheel and yankee feast on one-high.
- **Find the pairs.** Look at each side of the formation and ask which two or three receivers could work together. A slot and an outside receiver on the same side are a likely smash, flood or post-wheel; two slots on opposite sides are a likely mesh or shallow cross.
- **Man or zone?** Pressed corners, a defender following a motion man across the formation: think man, and think mesh, rubs and the angle route.

On the replay (the end-zone camera or the skycam is best)

- **Find the two-receiver combination on the side the ball went to.** Was one route above the other (a vertical stretch), side by side (horizontal), three in a triangle, or crossing (a man-beater)? Name the stretch, then name the concept.
- **Find the defender in conflict.** Who stood between the two routes? What did he do? The ball went to the receiver he didn't take.
- **Count the time.** A dropback concept takes about "one-thousand-one, one-thousand-two, one-thousand-three." If the ball is out before "two," it was the quick game.

For your prediction log (How to Watch a Broadcast): on each third-and-medium, write the shell you see and the concept family you expect (two-high: smash or dagger; man: mesh or rubs). Check yourself on the replay.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: two high, corners squatting

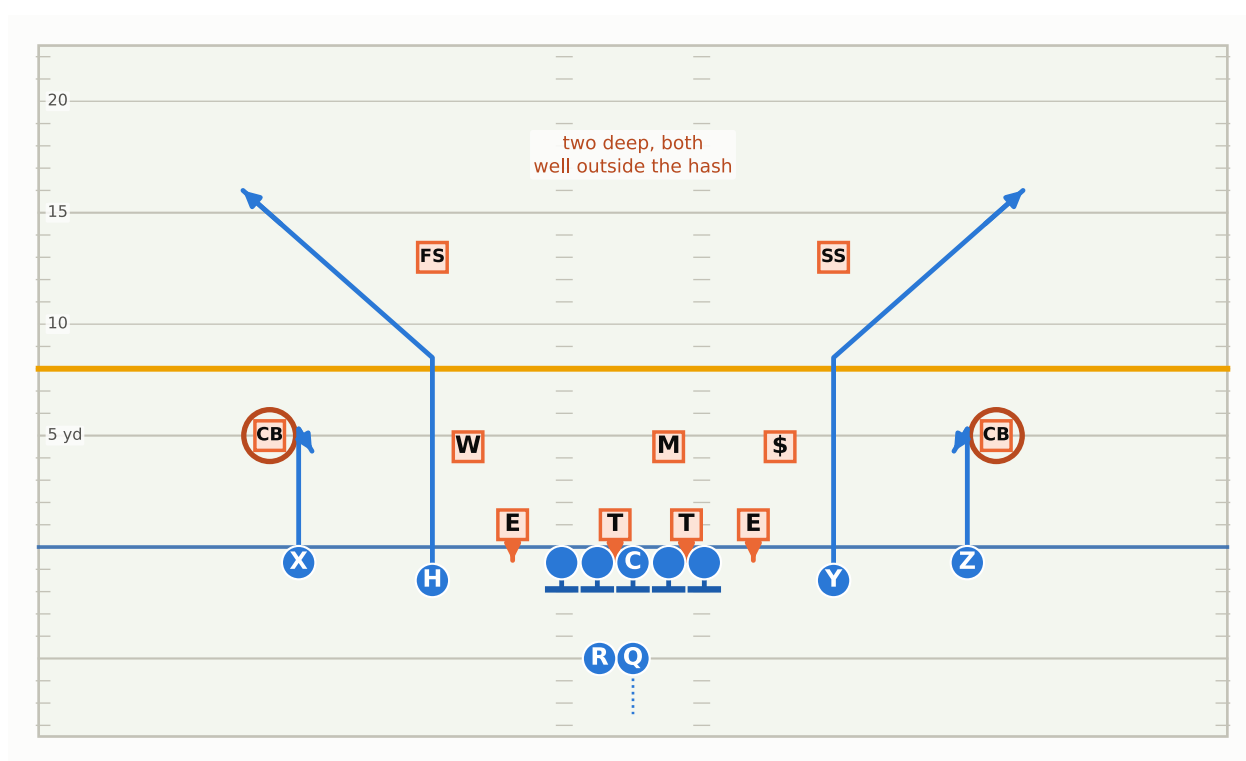


Figure 21: Third-and-8. The offense has called smash to both sides. The defense shows two deep safeties at about 13 yards, each well outside the hash, and both cornerbacks squatting five yards off with outside leverage. On the right, the nickel (\$) is lined up inside Y; on the left, the Will linebacker (W) is walked out over H.

Which route is the quarterback's first look, which defender does he watch, and what would make him come off it?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

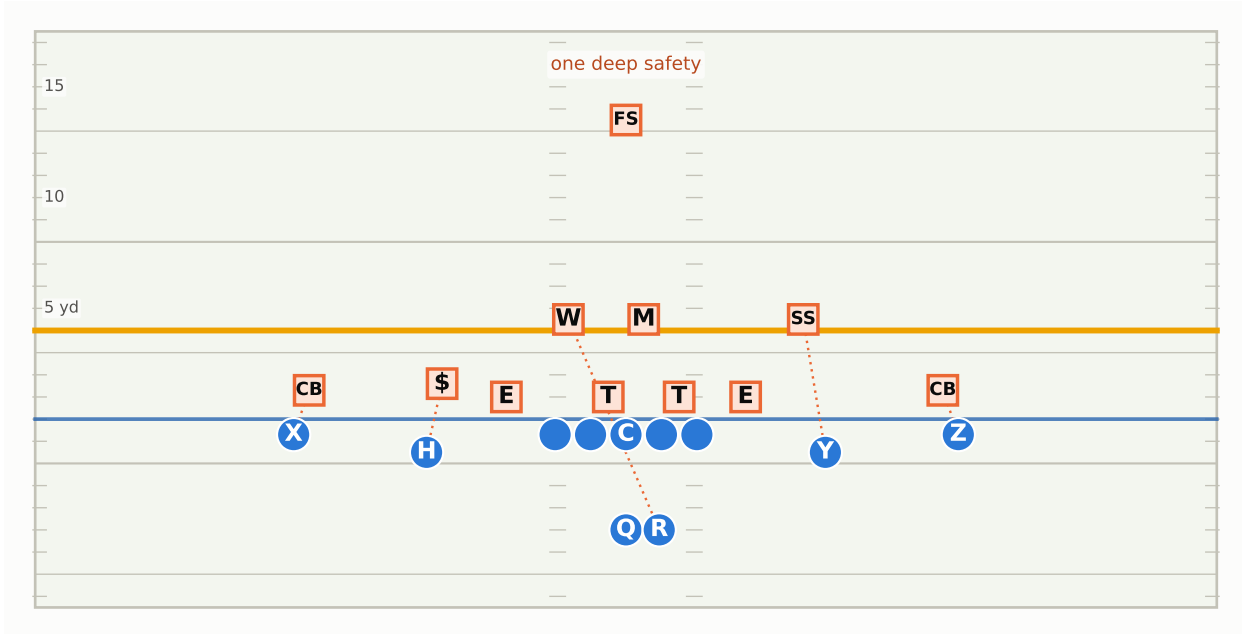


Figure 22: Third-and-4. Both cornerbacks are pressed on X and Z, the nickel (\$) is pressed on H, the strong safety stands across from Y, the Will is over the back, and one safety is deep in the middle. Before the snap, H went in motion across the formation and back; the nickel followed him all the way and back again.

The offense has three concepts on its call sheet for this situation: flood, four verticals and mesh. Which one should it run, and why?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: one safety, two seams

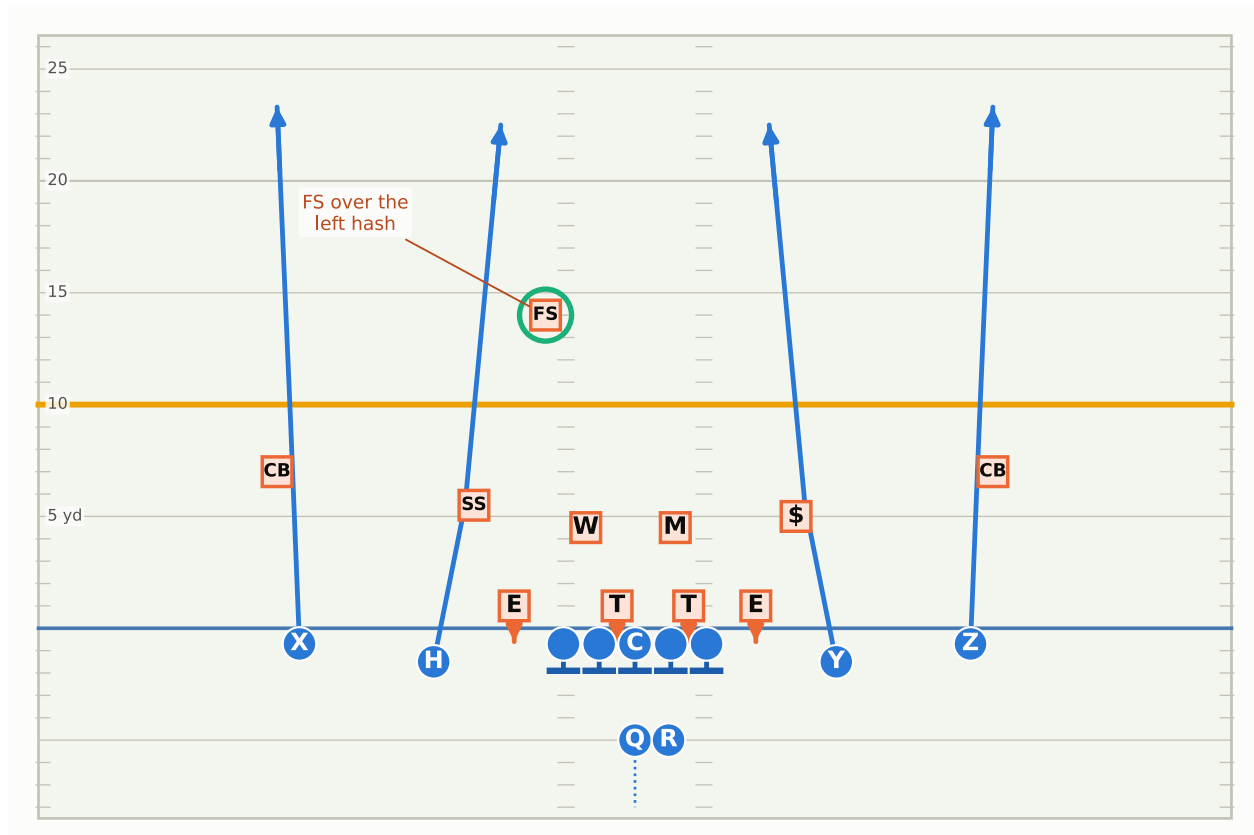


Figure 23: Second-and-10 from the offense's own 30. Four verticals is called. The defense shows one deep safety, but he has lined up over the left hash rather than in the middle, at about 14 yards. The cornerbacks are seven yards off with outside leverage.

Which seam should the quarterback expect to throw, and what should he do with his eyes?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- A **pass concept** is a set of routes built to work together, usually by putting one or two defenders in a bind; it has a name so the whole offense can learn and call it as a unit, from any formation.
- Concepts come in **four families**: **vertical stretches** (high-low: smash, flood, levels, drive, shallow cross, dagger, Y-cross, yankee), **horizontal stretches** (side to side, deep: four verticals, post-wheel, scissors), **triangles** (three receivers around two defenders: curl-flat, snag) and **man-beaters** (crossers, rubs and mismatches: mesh, the angle route).
- Each concept is built to beat certain coverages: smash and dagger attack **two-high**, flood, four verticals, post-wheel and yankee attack **one-high**, and mesh and the angle route attack **man**. That is why the quarterback's pre-snap read starts with the safeties.
- The quarterback reads **the defender in conflict, not the receivers**, and his progression runs on his feet: the first read as his back foot lands, the next on a hitch, the checkdown last.
- **Rub routes** beat man coverage by making defenders run through traffic; a receiver who deliberately blocks a defender more than a yard downfield before the ball is touched commits **offensive pass interference**.
- **Tags** change one route in a concept; **route conversions** let a route change itself by coverage, so one call can be right against several defenses. The **intermediate middle** of the field is the most valuable place to throw, and most of these concepts exist to get the ball there.

Connections

Builds on: The Quick Game (concepts, leverage, the pre-snap read and the short stretches this chapter takes deeper), Passing Fundamentals (routes, drops, progressions and the two stretches) and Pass Protection (the time these concepts need).

Sets up: Play-Action, Bootlegs, and Screens runs flood and yankee off a run fake; Quarterback Play covers progressions, the pocket and look-offs in depth; Offensive Systems and Languages shows how the West Coast, Erhardt-Perkins, Air Raid and Shanahan systems name and call these concepts. On defense, Coverage Fundamentals, Man Coverage and The Cover 3 Family show the other side of each matchup; What Beats What pairs every concept with the coverages it beats; and Contact Rules and Penalties covers how officials judge rubs and picks.

Case study: Walsh's 49ers and the West Coast offense, where curl-flat, the triangle and the timed dropback game were born.

[i Go deeper](#)

- Chris B. Brown, *The Essential Smart Football* (2012) and *The Art of Smart Football* (2015), and his Smart Football site: the clearest writing anywhere on smash, flood, mesh, Y-cross, levels and four verticals, and on why they work.
- S. C. Gwynne, *The Perfect Pass: American Genius and the Reinvention of Football* (2016): the story of Hal Mumme, Mike Leach and the Air Raid's small menu of concepts.
- Bill Walsh, with Brian Billick and James A. Peterson, *Finding the Winning Edge* (1998): the West Coast passing game, including its triangle reads, in the coach's own words.
- **From diagrams to real tracking data.** The two animations above are gridiron simulations in NFL Big Data Bowl coordinates. The 2025 Big Data Bowl release (2022 season, weeks 1–9) charts every receiver's route on every play, so you can find real four-verticals and mesh calls and watch them. The data needs a free Kaggle login, so this code is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

The corner route, read off the cornerback, with one eye on the safety. This is the picture smash was built for: Cover 2, two deep safeties and cornerbacks squatting short. Either side will do, because the defense is the same on both; many quarterbacks pick the side of the field with more room or the receiver they trust more.

After the snap, he watches the cornerback on that side. If the cornerback sits on the hitch (Cover 2 tells him to), the corner route is open behind him, and the throw has to get there before the safety, who starts thirteen yards deep and a few yards outside the hash, can run the fifteen yards to the sideline. If the cornerback sinks under the corner route instead, the hitch is open in front of him.

What would make him come off it? Two things. If the safety on that side doesn't backpedal but runs for the sideline at the snap, he is taking the corner route away, and the hitch (or the other side) is the throw. And if the cornerback bails deep at the snap, the "Cover 2" was a disguise for Cover 3 (see Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage): the corner route is now covered from above, and the hitch is the answer.

Answer 2.

Mesh. Everything here says man coverage: pressed cornerbacks, a defender over every receiver, a single safety deep, and, the clincher, a nickel who followed H across the formation and back on the motion. Zone defenders don't travel with a motion man; man defenders do (Motion and Shifts).

Against man, the zone-beaters lose their point. Flood's three levels stretch a curl-flat defender who doesn't exist; each receiver just has a defender following him. Four verticals is a better man answer but needs three seconds and a receiver who can beat a pressed cornerback deep, which is a big ask on third-and-4. Mesh is built for this: the two crossers run at five or six yards, close to the line to gain, and the defenders pressing H and Y have to fight through each other's traffic. One of the crossers usually comes free within two seconds, running away from his man.

What should worry the offense? The Mike linebacker. In Cover 1, the defender not assigned to anyone often sits in the middle as a robber, exactly where the crossers meet. The quarterback has to find him before the snap and throw the crosser running away from him.

Answer 3.

Y's seam, on the right, away from the safety, and he should look left first. One safety means Cover 3 (or Cover 1), and against four verticals that single safety is the man in conflict: two seams, one defender. He has already shaded toward the left seam before the snap, so the right seam starts with a head start of several yards.

But a good safety lines up off-center on purpose sometimes, to bait the throw and then race back to the middle. The quarterback's answer is his eyes: look at H's seam on the left as he drops, holding the safety there, then turn and throw to Y. That's the look-off from the animation above. If the safety ignores the eyes and runs right at the snap, H's seam on the left is open behind him, and if both seams are covered by the curl-flat defenders carrying them, the back underneath, settling over the ball, is the checkdown.